

The 8-Gate Framework — for teams building in defined stages.

If your team works in phases (discovery, design, build, QA) with handoffs and reviews, run every decision through these eight gates **in order** before you trust a synthetic-user result. Each gate is a checkpoint: pass it and advance, or fail it and get routed to real humans. The color tells you what kind of check it is and how hard it bites.

SEQUENTIAL — GATE 1 → GATE 8, EACH MUST PASS BEFORE THE NEXT

1 Clarify the decision

State the exact SaaS decision (pricing, onboarding, tier limit) in one sentence.

DISCOVERY

2 Check risk level

Is it irreversible, or does it touch billing, contracts, or security?

DEFINITION

3 Fit the question

A structured system / pricing-logic check — not open-ended discovery?

DEFINITION

4 Confirm real usage data

Do you have telemetry, logs, or interviews to ground the personas?

DISCOVERY

5 Define the persona

Specify role, permissions, seat / budget limits, and expertise level.

DESIGN

6 Calibrate on history

Reproduce a known past outcome; check drift before trusting new runs.

TEST & VALIDATE

7 Plan the human loop

Decide what humans validate; the go / no-go stays with real people.

TEST & VALIDATE

8 Set compliance guardrails

Tag AI-generated output, log prompts, and audit for bias.

LAUNCH & OPTIMIZE

■ reframe / scope down (1-2) ■ stop → go to real people (3, 4, 7) ■ recalibrate & re-test (5-6) ■ governance (8)

A "no" at any gate routes you — the color says where.